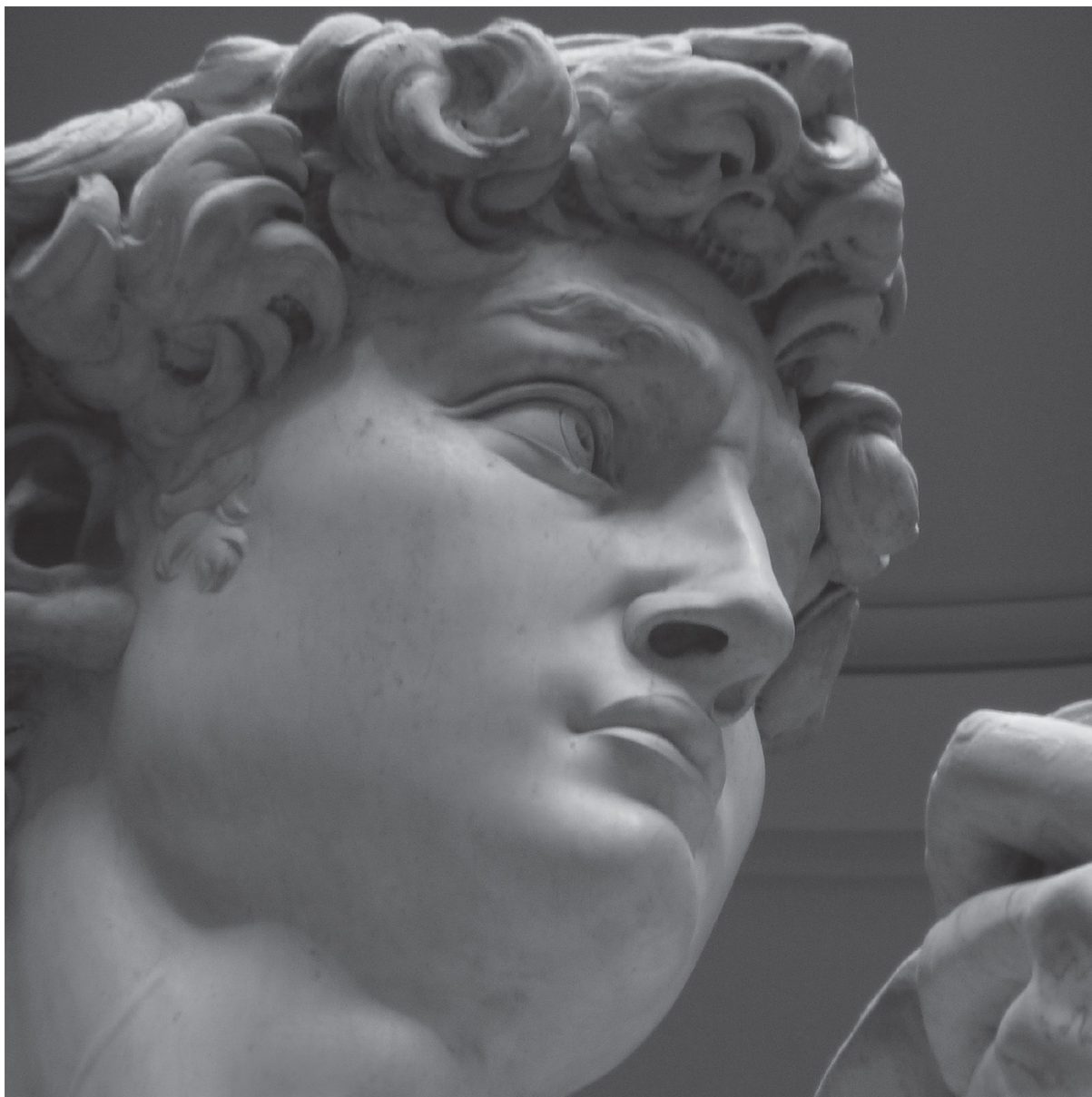


Sculpture

The earliest sculpture seems to have begun with artists modifying found objects to represent animal or human forms. As tools and technologies improved, artists progressed from carving bone, wood and stone to manipulating clay and firing in bronze. Today, a wide variety of materials are carved, welded, modelled, moulded and cast. In many cultures, sculpture has been central to religious ceremonies or political propaganda, and aside from pottery, stone sculpture represents most surviving three-dimensional art from ancient times – most wooden pieces are lost.

Sculpture of bronze and other alloys developed independently in various cultures, including South America, China, ancient Egypt and West Africa. Techniques include lost-wax casting, plaster-mould casting and sand casting. Wood carving flourished particularly in medieval Europe, and stone carving reached astonishing heights in ancient Greece and later during the Renaissance. Classical statues were usually painted to enhance their realism. From 1917, found objects were once again presented as finished works of art.



Michelangelo, *David*, 1501–4